



WELCOME ABOARD FLIGHT Indian Aviation. We are currently cruising at a high airspeed as a thousand more aircraft are set to take to the Indian skies after the Covid-19 lull. The weather looks good with the tailwind on our side as air travel demand is exploding among Indian passengers. But please be warned of a delay in reaching our destination as a great turbulence awaits: There may not be enough experienced pilots in the country to fly the thousand new planes.

62 |

Take a look at the numbers. Indian airlines have placed orders for at least 1,115 planes to be delivered over the next decade, with a bulk of them expected to come in after 2025. A narrow-body commercial plane that flies on domestic routes requires 14-16 pilots to ensure smooth operations, while a wide-body aircraft needs 24-26 pilots, per industry standards. As India has only a small proportion of wide-body planes, a conservative estimate of 15-16 pilots per plane means 17,000-18,000 pilots are required over the next decade. That is, 1,700-1,800 per year on

an average. But the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) registers only 600-750 commercial pilot licence (CPL) holders every year. "We will be off by 100 per cent within a few years. Even a 5-10 per cent shortage is considered a manpower challenge in any industry. So, if there's a 100 per cent shortage, it could mean you are dead and buried," says Hemanth D.P., CEO of Asia Pacific Flight Training Academy. Incidentally, India currently has 9,000 pilots who fly its 700 aircraft.

Aviation advisory and research firm CAPA India estimates that 150-175 of the new planes will arrive in 2024, and require 1,800-2,000 more pilots to fly them. "We need to triple our capacity," says Udit Agarwal, Team Lead, CAPA India. C.S. Randhawa, Secretary of the Federation of Indian Pilots (FIP), points out that the shortage is particularly of experienced captains with 3,000 flying hours (which is four to five years of flying experience) under their belts. As he sees the 1,100 ordered planes arriving within five years, he estimates India needs 1,400 captains (pilots) and 1,400 first officers (co-pilots) every year. "You may find first officers in the market because there are more than 2,000 unemployed CPL holders. But I don't foresee the industry producing more than 130 captains cumulatively. The shortfall is over 1,100 captains.

Where will they come from?"

Even though Go First has filed for bankruptcy, experts point out that the aircraft ordered by it can easily be picked up by other airlines given the rising air travel demand among Indians.

Former DGCA chief Arun Kumar pointed out in February that one in three trained pilots is without a job, which works out to more than 4,000 CPL holders. But, as experts say, many of them are not just unemployed but unemployable. India also lacks sufficient qualified trainers and quality infrastructure. Some schools allow over-logging of flying hours to fulfil the mandatory requirement of 200 hours and students lack solo flying experience, says Hemanth. Government data shows there were eight accidents in 2022 involving aircraft of DGCA-approved flying training organisations (FTOs). Last year, DGCA suspended the licences of 92 pilots for violating safety norms, which was more than double the 2021 figure. "If a pilot is just about able to make it, training schools give them an okay," says Amit Singh, Founder of Safety Matters Foundation, an NGO. Flying school trainers are usually those who couldn't become commercial pilots. They have little flying experience and the trainees, in turn, do not have a strong foundation, he adds.

A LONG-DRAWN PROCESS

To be sure, a pilot shortage is a medium-term problem. The cracks will become apparent once fleet induction starts, say experts. But the catch is that pilot training takes up to two years from start to finish. Plus, there is a six- to seven-month lead time between hiring and flying as the pilots have to go through airline-specific training. "The structural capacity is not available

Pilot shortage is a lose-lose situation for passengers, airlines and the country. Ramping up indigenous training infrastructure is the only long-term solution